

KF Mini-Meeting Lesson 16

--"MINI-MEETING" FORMAT-- (20 min)

I - MINDFULLNESS (4 min)

-ANB (1 min)

-3 Minute Breathing Space (3 min)

II - CHECK-IN (10 min)

-KF Member "A" shares (5 min)

(1) What I learned

(2) Signs of MO

(3) Signs of Orientation

(4) Five things I am thankful for

-KF Member "B" shares (5 min)

(1) What I learned

(2) Signs of MO

(3) Signs of Orientation

(4) Five things I am thankful for

III - KF MEETING "PREVIEW" (6 min)

-Bible Teaching -- selected excerpt of previous week KF Bible teaching (5 min)

-Ending Prayer (1 min)

BIBLE TEACHING

Turn in your Bibles to the Gospel of Matthew, chapter 7.

As we have said before, legal systems do not foster gratitude. When we expect people to act in a certain way, they can do no more than meet our expectations. When they do manage to comply, we feel no real gratitude for their efforts. We only experience a brief respite from our fear of not being in control. If people only approximate our expectations, there are no points in their favor. They have still failed to fulfill all the requirements of our imagined standards and, therefore, deserve our wrath. If, on the other hand, they do meet our expectations, they are not allowed to feel that they have given us a gift of any kind. They are only allowed to feel that they have escaped our wrath for a moment. Laws of shoulds and claims perpetuate ingratitude, fear, wrath, and resentment, not only toward others but toward ourselves.

Nancy studied First Corinthians 13 for many years without really understanding what Paul meant when he said, "Love does not insist on its own way, nor does it seek its own." One day, the meaning became clear to her—and it felt terrifying. She realized that if she wanted to express God's love through her life, she would have to give up her own ideas about how things should be. She would have to submit to God's way of doing things. Jesus taught us that if we insist on our own way, seeking the fulfillment of our shoulds, we will never experience our true glory. After several years of exploration, Nancy began to learn how to exchange her personal law of shoulds and claims for oriented, healthy desires. She learned not to insist on her own way, but to meet her needs and attain her wants by asking, seeking, and knocking. This is what Jesus Himself taught us to do in **Matthew 7:7–8**. Let's listen to these verses in Nancy's translation:

⁷Ask, and it will be given to you; seek, and you will find; knock, and it will be opened to you. ⁸This is how it works: the asking one receives, the seeking one finds, and to the knocking one it will be opened.

Take a deep breath. You might like to read the whole of chapter 7 in Matthew's Gospel and notice how the Bible supports what we teach in Karis Fellowships. In the passage for this lesson, Jesus encourages us to stop wasting energy on trying to impose our shoulds and claims; instead, He invites us to learn the process of asking, seeking, and knocking. It's important to point out here that asking, seeking, and knocking are all qualities of a person. If you are the kind of person who keeps asking, the kind of person who keeps seeking, and the kind of person who keeps knocking on a regular basis, then Jesus is talking about you.

Asking is Words

Tell God and others what is going on inside your skin. Do you know that other people can't read your mind? It is an infantile claim to expect them to do so. Toddlers learn to use their words, and so can you. Telling others what is going on inside you is not a license to impose your demands on others and the world, nor is it an opportunity to voice your opinions about what they should or should not do to accommodate you. It is learning to express your own reality in a moderate way. Moderate expression is evidence that you have done your own work and attended to your own business. After you've done your work, you can use words to speak your reality moderately and communicate what you would prefer.

Seeking is Attitude

When our seeking is motivated by the True Self, we are open to what we can learn about ourselves, about others, and about our environment. We are not attached to an outcome that we, in our omniscient and self-righteous judgment, have deemed to be right or good. Seeking is a journey, and it opens up the possibilities of unforeseen discoveries and delightful surprises.

You might ask: *If I am to seek, how do I know what to seek?* You are seeking the attributes of love, which will produce the Fruit of the Spirit in your life—and if you make love your destination, you will discover other valuable things along the way, like your True Self.

Knocking is Action

Explore an oriented action and see what happens. When you find an opportunity, use your courage and endurance to keep knocking on the door of that opportunity or, as Nancy did, to keep looking for the key. You really have to give up the idea that you already know what should be behind the door. With real effort and an open mind, you can knock in the face of your fears and grow through your past mistakes. A door in your mind may open, or a door to your future may open—it's really the same thing.

We often forget that the solutions to our problems are not simply a matter of just asking. Our Idol remembers only the *ask and you shall receive* part. Asking is the easy part, and when we have done our part by asking, we hope that God will do the rest. Sometimes we have heard A-S-K, an acronym for Ask – Seek – Knock, so often that we have forgotten that oriented results come from a three-step process. So, here's another way to think about it: W-A-A—*Words, Attitude, Action. (Repeat)*

This is the time to exercise the kind of self-discipline that an excellent father would teach you. Don't just cry "Waa!" like an immature child or act like a victim whining to the universe and blaming self, circumstances, God, and others. Instead, you can think: WAA!—Words, Attitude, Action. Use moderate words to ask so that you and others can understand what you want. Seek with an open attitude, without judgment, looking for something real that will be revealed. Knock because only action produces reaction—and if you want to make something oriented happen, you have to take oriented action. You don't just sit around, indulge your feelings, or follow distracting rabbit trails; nor do you hold others, including God, responsible for your business. Instead, you actively look for a key under the doormat.

Our prayer might go something like this:

Holy Spirit, remind me to use Words, Attitude, Action. (Repeat)

Take a deep breath.

ENDING PRAYER

Dear Father and Creator,

Thank You for this time to heal and train together. Hold us in the power of this redirected energy as You guide us to our real glory and mission. Lead us to the next step in our healing this week as we co-labor with You to reorient our lives for a more effective flow and to flourish in our connection with our True Self, with the Creation, and with You, for the glory and honor of our Lord Jesus. Amen.

Take a deep breath.